

In Need of Consoling

Agent 001 takes a peek at the console market and walks away a satisfied gamer

After you have stumbled by the bit about the birds and the bees, the next revelation to hit you is that 'A thing of beauty can be a pain to behold'. Case in point: the big beige box. As most of us find out sooner or later, the computer is a beautiful gaming machine for sure, right up to the point when you wish to play something on it—like *Grand Theft Auto III*. The game insisted on displaying a garbled mess of popping textures and running colours on my PC—the PC with the GeForce3 Ti200 video card that I had poured five months of savings into, so that I could play the latest games... like *Grand Theft Auto III*. Patches be damned! I was getting sick of this mess and was pondering over the likely course of action to take (introducing my PC to a healthy supply of explosives, crossed my mind more than once) when a friend interrupted my reverie. He asked me to come over to his place to check out his Sony PlayStation 2. He demonstrated his 'beautiful baby' with the help of 'this really cool game': *Grand Theft Auto III*! Life was trying to tell me something. It was time I listened and set out to check out this whole console scene.

For those of you who joined in late, here is a brief on the gaming scene in India. The landscape is a desert, with just enough signs of life to keep you heading for the oasis that must surely be nearby. The console market is no different; Sony

come upwards of Rs 700. But do ensure that the games are the real deal.

Moving on, I half-stumbled over the Sega Dreamcast. This 128-bit console has officially landed on our shores, sells for about Rs 6,500 and has a healthy collection of some excellent titles from Sega and third-party developers alike. Although Sega has ceased production, there is enough stock left to keep the Dreamcast in circulation for a while. Original titles are a rare breed that sell for Rs 500 to Rs 550; the pirated games are more common, selling for as low as Rs 75.

While the Dreamcast is an attractive buy, Sony's boys are hogging all the limelight.

The PSOne sells for about Rs 4,000, with games available both officially (priced between Rs 499 and Rs 1,499) and illegally (from Rs 35 to Rs 50).

The PS2 meanwhile, has the largest game library, beautiful graphics, sports perhaps the best game controller, holds a seemingly unassailable lead in the console

race and is super-chic to boot. All that at a hefty Rs 18,000! Alas, it is a grey market commodity, and is often sold with a mod chip: something that lets you play illegal or pirated versions of a game. The games themselves come in both the original form (Rs 1,499 and above) and the illegal kind, selling at Rs 80 to Rs 250.

Racing alongside the PS2 is the Nintendo Gamecube and the Microsoft Xbox. While my sources reveal that the Gamecube has been recently sighted in Delhi, it is still a pie-in-the-sky for the most part. The Xbox, however is here to stay—priced at Rs 20,000, also a grey market buy and modded to go, its presently-limited stable of games are sold illegally at around Rs 450.

So which one did I buy? With a humble budget of Rs 5,000, I pocketed the GBA, plus a few games to go. *Grand Theft Auto III* will have to wait. ☞



ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

has made some headway into this segment with its PlayStation and now, the PlayStation 2 (PS2). The best selling consoles, however still reside in the era of 8-bit gaming—the Nintendo NES (Nintendo Entertainment System) clones, with libel-attracting names like PolyStation and a price tag that ranges from Rs 200 to Rs 700, depending upon the peripherals that you buy alongside. The games that run on these machines come on cartridges for Rs 30 and above.

As I delved deeper into this underground scene, the PolyStations slowly gave way to more attractive options like the Game Boy Advance (GBA). Thanks to a vividly coloured screen and a bevy of excellent games, the GBA is a pocket-sized haven for the fun-loving types. The console itself sells for around Rs 3,600, while the games, sold on cartridges,



SHOPPING TIP

- If you are into gaming on the move, look no further than the Game Boy Advance.
- The best console to buy would currently be the Sony PlayStation 2. For a cheaper alternative, nothing beats the PSOne.
- As far as possible, make sure that the game titles you purchase are the real deal. Pirated games are an unreliable buy.
- Most consoles are bundled with at least one controller; ensure that you are not short-changed on this aspect.